

**At the Canadian Open, the red-hot 19-year-old Spaniard knocked out Lorenzo Musetti, Jiri Lehecka and Arthur Fils in straight sets.** Jim Courier called the rookie pro's rocket ascent this year from No. 165 to No. 11 "astonishing". But he's no flash in the pan. "Because he has such a balanced game, he should have staying power," said Courier.

The new Rafa looks and plays nothing like the legend. Jodar is a lanky 6'3" right-hander with conventional strokes, all-out aggression, and modest defensive skills — as opposed to Nadal's husky, biceps-bulging 6'1" physique and quintessential left-handed topspin game with ultra-high-percentage tactics ideal for clay.

Jodar has racked up wins over Fils (twice), Musetti (twice), Alex de Minaur, Joao Fonseca, and Lehecka in his breakthrough year. Two stats bolster Spanish hopes for the new Rafa: he ranks No. 4 among ATP Return Leaders and No. 5 in Break Points Converted Average at 44.0 per cent.

**Prediction: Quarterfinals**

**RAFAEL JODAR**

**No.11**



**No. 6**



**BEN SHELTON**

**If Ben Shelton wins the US Open, he'll become the first American man to capture a Grand Slam singles title since Andy Roddick at Flushing Meadows in 2003.** Like

Roddick, now a *Tennis Channel* analyst, Shelton features a rocket serve

and a strong forehand, but a mediocre backhand. Although Shelton hasn't fared well at the Majors this year, he's showcased his all-surface versatility by capturing four tournaments. He won Munich on clay, Stuttgart on grass, and Dallas and Montreal on hard courts. After defeating Brandon Nakashima 6-3, 7-6(4) in the Montreal final to defend his title without losing a set, former No. 1 Jim Courier said, "This is the best string of matches he's ever put together. The return of serve [rated 7.6 versus 5.4 for Nakashima] looks better than when he won here last year."

**Prediction: Semifinals**

**ARTHUR FILS**

**No. 21**



**Going into the Cincinnati Open, Arthur Fils ranked No. 1 with a 265.9 rating — significantly ahead of Sinner (259.5), Auger-Aliassime (248.6), Djokovic (243.9), and Alcaraz (243.7).** Amazingly, he's won 100 per cent of his matches that had a deciding set. His increased stamina and speed this season resulted partly from eliminating cookies from his diet last year and losing 15 pounds. "Fils has so much potential," Courier said during the Frenchman's 6-3, 6-2 quarterfinal victory over Tirante at the Cincinnati Open. One key to reaching his potential is using his massive forehand more effectively, which averages a Tour-leading 83 mph, enhanced by a 3,300 RPM spin rate. Besides his title-winning effort at the Barcelona Open, he has consistently excelled on hard courts, winning Cincinnati and reaching the final in Doha, the semifinals in Miami, and the quarterfinals at Indian Wells, Montpellier and Montreal.

**Prediction: Semifinals**